



When sci-fi meets reality

If you took this month's Digit, and gave it to someone in 1979, they'd ask you whether it was some new sci-fi publication. That's the beauty of technology and the way it has exploded into our lives over the past three decades.

Today, you and I are doing things with gadgets and computers that no one, except for a few sci-fi writers, would have dreamt possible a few decades back. However, almost everything we can touch and feel today was indeed the stuff of dreams and the fantasy worlds of dreamers such as Issac Asimov and Arthur C Clarke have been used as fuel to carve our current slice of reality. It's almost as if most of humanity's inventions are the result of our sci-fi fed imaginations, and research dollars spent to make those dreams a reality. The internet, the moon landings, handheld computers, tiny cameras, robotic assembly lines, artificial satellites, word-wide TV networks, instantaneous information flow, the orgasmatron, all of this was "imagined" by sci-fi writers as much as a century before even rudimentary versions of these were available.

Perhaps it's because I've been a sci-fi bookworm from the age of five, or because of my constant exposure to technology at Digit over the years; but nothing shocks me anymore. I'm quite sure a lot of you feel the same, and need something special to happen before you're "amazed" again. For example, after Atari, Nintendo and Sega got us used to playing computer games on our home TVs back in the 80s, nothing, not even the powerful PS3 from Sony was really an eye-opener. I don't mean to be a wet blanket, but from the early 80s to sometime in November 2006, if you wanted to play video games, you needed a comfortable chair or a sofa. All that changed over the years was that the graphics got better — which, frankly, was expected. Then came the Wii, and a lot of us had to sit up and take notice; actually, we had to stand up and move to play it — no prizes for guessing which game console is the top seller.

Another thing technology has done is shrunk the generation divide. 30 years ago, if the age difference between two people across a generation gap was 20 years, today it's more like five years.

For example, it's interesting to note that all my friends and colleagues who are

less than five years older or younger than me hate the whole Twitter phenomenon, and yet there are so many 15 to 25 year olds Twittering away their time. Personally, I think it's just a waste of time with a lot of bad language (SMS speak) thrown in, but with millions of users across the globe who disagree, I'm forced to admit that it's perhaps just not my cup of tea.

However, let's not twitter on about minor differences in taste, what I'm trying to get at is that although we still have our likes and dislikes, and a billion choices, none of us can really get back to the childish awe and wonderment that we experience when we are witness to great innovations.

Can you imagine how people felt when they watched the first moon landing on TV, or how bystanders gasped in wonderment as the Orville brothers took flight? These days we expect innovation, and are sometimes peeved when technology lags behind — such as the way we moan about crawling hard drives, or the lack of AI.

This is why we need more innovation, or at least more sci-fi turning reality.

We've tried to give you a small glimpse of the future to come, in the pages that follow — from engines that will drive our future, to the plans that various space agencies have put in place as a roadmap to our exploring our solar system. Edward's article on the Large Hadron Collider (LHC) also puts across some possible scary outcomes of the testing being done there. We also look at some interesting technology depicted in popular movies, and find out how close to reality sci-fi has become. Although, sadly, we're still a long way off from colonising the solar system, and thankfully, don't have to worry about AI taking over the world, Terminator-style, we're already headed towards becoming cyborgs and preparing to use little nano-bots to clear blocked arteries — not quite the *Fantastic Voyage*, but fantastic enough.

In this issue and the ones that follow, we're going to try and show you facets of science and technology that will re-capture your imagination...



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